

10 Experiments in Public Policy and What We Can Learn From Them

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- ▶ Associate Prof of Government
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- ▶ Associate Director, Center for Data Science
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- ▶ **Senior Social Scientist**
(The Lab @ DC)
- ▶ **Fellow in Methodology (US Office of
Evaluation Sciences: “OES”)**

What Am I Doing Here??

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► in **England?**

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(If you need to leave, due to other extra-curricular responsibilities, I understand.)

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(No pressure.)

ESS: Making Connections

Deep Essex-Waseda connections

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Waseda University Mission

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Deep Essex-Waseda connections

Waseda University Mission

“Waseda University pledges to contribute to the progress of the times by establishing **a path for the practical use of scholarship** as well as pursuing theoretical research for its own sake.”



Goals

- ▶ Inspire your thinking about what *could* be an experiment (our best hope for causal inference)

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- ▶ Introduce you to some results from experiments in the field
- ▶ Draw out lessons for applied, community-based (and academic) research

Ten Randomised Experiments in Public Policy

Ten Randomised Experiments in Public Policy

1. Seguro Popular
2. 911 Nurse Triage Line
3. Welfare Recertification, TANF
4. Retirement Savings, 457b
5. Police Body-Worn Cameras
6. Flexible, Shallow Rent Housing Subsidy
7. Police training, Nat Museum of African-American History and Culture
8. Warning Taxpayers about Preparers
9. Opioid Buyback
10. Fire Inspectors Risk-Score Lists

Seguro Popular

- ▶ *Partner:* Mexican federal government and health bureaucracy
- ▶ *Intervention:* Randomise federal health infrastructure spending, household insurance to Mexican households
- ▶ *Finding:* Reduced catastrophic health expenditures for households
- ▶ *A Lesson:* Applied work can inspire new methodological research

(King et al. 2007, 2009; Moore 2012)

Nurse Triage Line

- ▶ *Partner:* DC Fire and Emergency Management Services
- ▶ *Intervention:* Randomise whether 911 emergency callers talk to a nurse
- ▶ *Finding:* Reduced ambulance dispatches, transports; increased primary care visits
- ▶ *A Lesson:* Advocates matter. Even when seems impossible, there may be a way. Effects can be huge (40pp).

(Wilson et al. 2024)

Welfare Recertification, TANF

- ▶ *Partner*: DC Human Services
- ▶ *Intervention*: Randomised whether households due to recertify received a behaviourally-informed reminder letter
- ▶ *Finding*: Improved recertification rates, especially when we indicate flexibility
- ▶ *A Lesson*: We can build *capacity* in partners

(Moore et al. 2022)

Retirement Savings of Public Employees

- ▶ *Partner*: DC Human Resources
- ▶ *Intervention*: Randomised email with simplified decisions and present-framing future gains
- ▶ *Finding*: Improved contributions for those *already* contributing, but 0 new contributors
- ▶ *A Lesson*: Human behaviour is sticky!

Police Body-worn Cameras

- ▶ *Partner*: DC Metro Police Department
- ▶ *Intervention*: Randomised whether police officers wore body-cameras
- ▶ *Finding*: No detectable effects on police use of force, citizen complaints, police activity
- ▶ *A Lesson*: Null effects can happen for many reasons, are important to share, and do not doom a program

(Yokum, Ravishankar, and Coppock 2019)

DC Flex: Flexible, shallow subsidy

- ▶ *Partner:* DC Housing and Homelessness agencies
- ▶ *Intervention:* Flexible, shallow rent subsidy
- ▶ *Finding:* Null effects on homelessness, but decreased use of other services (first year)
- ▶ *A Lesson:* Giving needy control can simplify administration without adverse outcomes

(Alva et al. 2023)

Police Training at Nat'l Museum of African-American History and Culture

- ▶ *Partner:* MPD, Nat Museum of African-American History and Culture
- ▶ *Intervention:* Randomized training of police officers on history of race and policing
- ▶ *Finding:* (Stay tuned!)
- ▶ *A Lesson:* Experiments can be imperfect, and approximate observational studies

Warning Taxpayers about Preparers

- ▶ *Partner:* US Tax Service (IRS)
- ▶ *Intervention:* Letters to taxpayers with info about their tax preparers
- ▶ *Finding:* Changed taxpayer filing behavior
- ▶ *A Lesson:* Well-designed experiments can measure interference/spillovers

Opioid Buyback

- ▶ *Partner:* Veterans Affairs Hospital
- ▶ *Intervention:* Reminder card mailed one week after surgery
- ▶ *Finding:* Improved rates of return by 30% (7pp)
- ▶ *A Lesson:* Connect at a reasonable, appropriate moment

Fire Inspector Risk-Score Lists

- ▶ *Partner:* DC Fire Inspectors
- ▶ *Intervention:* Randomize whether inspectors receive lists of buildings that come from *high risk scores* or *all risk scores*
- ▶ *Finding:* Scores predictive, lists promote exploration, coarse scores → reported violations
- ▶ *A Lesson:* We can combine data science predictive modeling and field experiments fruitfully; models should be validated in the field.

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(why aren't *worst* violations in data??)

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(EMS, pothole team, fire inspectors, ...)

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- ▶ Fastest way to learn: watch the experts

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 - ▶ Clustered designs
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 - ▶ Rerandomization for interference
 - ▶ Asymmetric eligibility
 - ▶ Orthogonal designs
- ▶ Help build capacity

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 - ▶ Avoid harm, gain consent
 - ▶ We are constantly “experimenting”
 - ▶ Resources are limited
 - ▶ Agents really do want to learn

Thank you!
Stay in touch!

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